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US MACRO INSIGHTS

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FOMC Recap: Nobody puts Powell in a corner

"I will leave when I think it is appropriate to do so."

– Chair Jerome Powell

In its April meeting, the Federal Open Market Committee (FOMC) maintained its policy rate at an upper bound of 3.75%, pausing for the third consecutive time and following three cuts at the end of 2025. The decision was split, with eight voters in favor and four against, the most dissent since October 1992.

The vote and communication are indicative of a genuine split about the inflation outlook and knock-on effects of the energy shock. We believe that these dissents are a preview of the contentious meetings to come for the rest of the year.

In the press conference, Chair Powell indicated that he intends to remain on the Fed Board as a governor after his term as Chair ends. He expressed concern about the series of legal attacks on him and clarified that the legal actions and not criticism from the Fed policy, have driven his decision to stay. He said he would like to retire but feels as if he has no choice but to stay.

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In its April meeting, the Federal Open Market Committee (FOMC) maintained its policy rate at an upper bound of 3.75%, pausing for the third consecutive time. The decision to keep the rates unchanged was nearly unanimous as there was only one dissent from Governor Miran favoring a 25bp cut, while Cleveland Fed President Beth Hammack, Dallas Fed President Lorie Logan, and Minneapolis Fed President Neel Kashkari dissented to the dovish tone of the official statement. Given the genuine divide on the economic outlook in the face of still-elevated inflation and uncertainty of the Iran war, we expect dissents for the rest of the year.

The statement was mixed. On the hawkish side, the statement now categorizes inflation as “elevated” (as opposed to “somewhat elevated” previously), which can be read as the FOMC being less tolerant of higher inflation. But trumping this language, and likely the reason for the three dissents is the continued inclusion of a reference to “the extent and timing of additional adjustments to the target range for the federal funds rate.”

In the press conference, Chair Powell indicated that he intends to remain on the Fed Board as a governor after his term as Chair ends. He expressed concern about the series of legal attacks on him and clarified that the legal actions and not criticism from the Fed policy, has driven his decision to stay. He said he would like to retire but feels as if he has no choice but to stay. He indicated that his continued presence is intended to help safeguard the Fed’s independence from political pressures and stated that he will leave “when I think it is appropriate to do so.”

What to expect going forward?

The Fed is likely to approach the coming quarters with a bias toward caution, balancing still-elevated inflation against a gradually softening growth backdrop. While inflation remains above target, policymakers will be particularly focused on preventing the recent energy-driven price shock—stemming from the Iran conflict—from feeding into broader, more persistent core inflation dynamics. In prior episodes, the Fed has tended to “look through” commodity-driven spikes when they are judged to be transitory, but the current environment—characterized by lingering price pressures—raises the bar for doing so.

A near-term uptick in headline inflation would not be surprising given higher oil prices and tariff-related effects. However, the Fed’s reaction function will hinge on whether these forces are clearly identifiable as one-off, exogenous shocks or whether they begin to bleed into underlying inflation measures. The distinction is critical: policymakers will want evidence that core inflation is not re-accelerating on a sustained basis, particularly through services inflation or wage growth. If inflation prints are elevated but compositionally narrow and tied to these shocks, the Committee is more likely to maintain its current stance rather than tighten further.

Our base case is that the energy shock dissipates over the coming months, limiting the risk of a renewed acceleration in inflation. While price growth may remain somewhat elevated relative to target, the absence of broad-based pressure should give the Fed greater confidence that inflation is continuing to trend in the right direction. This would align with a framework in which temporary supply shocks are treated as a drag on real incomes rather than a trigger for additional policy restraint.

Against this backdrop, the growth side of the mandate becomes increasingly relevant. If the economy slows as expected and labor market conditions soften—without a de-anchoring of longer-term inflation expectations—the Fed will have scope to ease policy. Indeed, this scenario is our expectation, and we believe cuts will be forthcoming in September and December.

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